Why compost at home

About a third of what a typical household throws away is food scraps and garden waste. Composting turns that into a dark, crumbly soil improver in three to twelve months, depending on how often the heap is turned.

A home compost bin also cuts the weight of the rubbish bin, which matters where collection is charged by weight. Most households that start composting say the kitchen bin needs emptying about half as often.

Greens and browns

Compost needs two kinds of material. Greens are wet and rich in nitrogen: fruit and vegetable scraps, coffee grounds, tea leaves and fresh grass clippings. Browns are dry and rich in carbon: dry leaves, shredded cardboard, egg boxes and straw.

A good working mix is roughly three parts browns to one part greens by volume. Too many greens make a wet, smelly heap; too many browns make a heap that barely warms up. The table below gives typical carbon-to-nitrogen ratios.

Material	Type	C:N ratio
Grass clippings	Green	20:1
Vegetable scraps	Green	25:1
Coffee grounds	Green	20:1
Dry leaves	Brown	60:1
Cardboard	Brown	350:1
Straw	Brown	80:1

Keeping the heap healthy

Turn the heap every two to three weeks with a garden fork to let air in. A working heap feels like a wrung-out sponge: damp, but not dripping. In the middle of an active heap the temperature can reach 55 to 65 degrees Celsius, hot enough to kill most weed seeds.

Never add meat, fish, dairy, cooked food with oil, or pet waste. They attract rats and can carry disease. Diseased plants and perennial weed roots are also best kept out of a cool home heap.

When it's ready

Finished compost is dark brown, smells of earth, and you can no longer recognise what went in, apart from the odd eggshell. Sieve out anything coarse and put it back in the bin to break down further.

Spread a layer about 5 centimetres deep around shrubs and on vegetable beds in spring, or mix one part compost with three parts soil for planting pots.